

Section 1: General Information

The teachers and staff of Troy Adventist Academy (TAAP) welcome you and your child. As a parent, your input is important in helping us make the days your child spends with us safe and happy. Please read the Parent Handbook carefully and keep it for your reference. Feel free to visit and become an active part of our preschool at any time.

Our Philosophy: Troy Adventist Academy Preschool (TAAP) has been founded to minister to the needs of families in our community. We believe that every child is a precious gift from God, and it is our desire to provide a place where children are cherished and their families feel respected and welcomed every day.

General Information: TAAP is licensed by the Michigan Department of Licensing and Regulatory Affairs (LARA). A copy of our current license is posted in a prominent location at our school. Our licensed capacity is 98. To be licensed, our preschool must comply with official licensing regulations. We have on the premises a copy of the governing statutes and rules, which is available to interested parents for review. Our Licensing Notebook, which contains all the licensing inspection and special investigation reports and related corrective action plans for the last five years is made available during regular business hours. Licensing inspection and special investigation reports from at least the past three years are available on the child care licensing website at www.michigan.gov/michildcare. Should you have any concerns or questions, you may call the toll free number listed on the license.

TAAP's general hours of operation are 7:00 am to 6:00 pm*, Monday through Friday. We operate four classrooms:

Infant/Young Toddlers – Ages 6 weeks to 30 months

Toddlers - 2 year olds

Preschool - 3-4 year olds

PreKindergarten Room - 4-5 year olds

We accept children for enrollment on a first-come-first-served basis without regard to race, religion, nationality, or gender.

**In honor of the Biblical Sabbath, which is observed from sundown Friday until sundown Saturday, TAAP closes early on some Fridays during the late fall and the winter. Please refer to the yearly calendar for specific dates for these closings, as well as closings for specific holidays.*

Section 2: My Child's Daily Activities

Our Caring Staff: At TAAP, we do our best to choose staff members who are qualified and well trained. We look for people who want the very best for your child and are willing to go the extra mile to provide a loving and nurturing environment every day. All staff members must provide evidence of good health and submit both a criminal background check with fingerprinting and a child abuse/neglect background check from the Department of Human Services with no negative findings. They complete a minimum of sixteen hours of training each year in areas relevant to child care and development. Volunteers (including students completing requirements for classes, or parents of children in care) must be cleared with the office, and are never left with children unsupervised unless they have completed all background check and training requirements.

Playtime and Learning Time: For children, playtime is learning time. At TAAP, we provide plenty of time each day for free play and exploration. As children grow, we provide developmentally appropriate activities designed to invite children to learn and explore. These include small and large group activities, learning centers, sensory and dramatic play, art and music experiences, and opportunities to participate in early math, science, and literacy experiences. We try to provide a balance of active and quiet activities and both staff initiated and child initiated experiences. We want your child to develop in all areas: physical, social, emotional, and cognitive. We plan our curriculum to combine the best of various styles of teaching and learning in an effort to provide a climate in which all children may thrive.

Outdoor Play: Although we have a large indoor play area which we use for special fitness activities and on days when it is very hot, cold, or wet, we endeavor to take all the children outside whenever the weather permits. Children in attendance must have proper clothing for outdoor conditions, including coats, hats, mittens, boots, and snow pants as needed.

Rest Time: There is a quiet time for rest each afternoon following lunch. The room lights are dimmed and quiet music plays. Staff members help each child settle and relax so they can get the rest they need.

Snack and Meal Time: At TAAP, nutritious vegetarian meals and snacks are included in the program. Staff supervision during

the serving of lunch and snack promotes a pleasant and relaxed atmosphere. We do our best to serve food the children will enjoy and encourage them to eat well, but food is never forced on a child. Monthly menus are posted and available for parents to take home for reference. Children who are here for a full day will also receive a morning and afternoon snack. Please do not send candy or gum to the school. Special treats may be sent for birthdays and holidays. However, please make arrangements with the staff before sending any food items to the school. Please note that some classrooms are nut free environments. Please let us know if you need gluten free or dairy free options, as these are available upon request.

The meal program at TAAP does not include formula or baby food for children too young to eat solid food. Parents of infants, therefore, will wish to provide the formula and food their little one requires. Some parents of older children may also wish to provide food from home for their children. If you would like to do this, please refer to the "Written Agreement for Parent provided Meals" which is included with your enrollment packet.

Note: *Children in the infant area both eat and sleep on demand. Until they are ready to fit in to a classroom schedule, their daily schedule is personalized to meet their needs.*

Discipline and Classroom Management: TAAP maintains a positive approach as a method of guidance and discipline. Early childhood is a time of rapid growth and transition, and children experience big emotions that challenge their ability to control or express them. It is our job as caregivers to make "being good" as easy as possible for them as they grow into their own personalities. Discipline guidelines are as follows: *All methods will be positive and consistent with the developmental needs of the child. Desirable behavior will be actively promoted, talked about, encouraged, and praised. (Desirable behaviors include listening and following directions, being kind to others, and staying safe.) The staff will be present and attentive to children, redirecting when necessary with a touch or an encouraging word, and offering them the opportunity to make good choices throughout the day. When intervention is required, children may be seated away from the group until they can settle down and make a better choice.*

These types of discipline will never be acceptable: *Hitting, pushing, jerking, threatening or frightening, isolating, ridicule, humiliation, or the withholding of kindness, love, food, or rest.*

Children who persist to engage in uncontrollable behavior that becomes disruptive or harmful to themselves or others will not be allowed to continue at TAAP.

Section 3: What Will I Need to Provide for My Child?

Application and Records: After you have visited our facility and decided that it is the right place for your child, your next step will be completing the forms in the enrollment packet and providing the records required by the state and by our center. Please refer to the checklist included with your enrollment packet for the complete list of requirements and a schedule for maintaining up to date information and medical records. Your child's file is confidential and will be shared with other staff members only as required to meet the needs of the child.

Everyday Needs: These are the items your child will need each day:

*A small pillow and blanket/sheet for nap time,
or a crib sheet for infants.*

*A complete change of seasonally appropriate
clothing that fits your child.*

*A stuffed animal to cuddle with at nap time is optional.
Diapers and wipes for children who are not toilet trained.*

*Formula/food for infants or children who will not be
eating the meals the center provides.*

All articles of clothing, including outerwear, boots, blankets, etc. must be clearly labeled with your child's full name. Your child's clothing is changed when wet or soiled as needed. Your child should be dressed in clothing appropriate for active play, ease in using the restroom, and for daily outdoor activities. We recommend sneakers or rubber-soled gym shoes for safe play.

If you send food, it must be clearly labeled with your child's full name and the date it is provided.

It is best if your child's personal toys and books are left at home. TAAP staff cannot be responsible for loss or damage to personal items.

Section 4: Parental Rights and Responsibilities

Parent Access: Parents of enrolled children are always welcome here and are permitted free access, without prior notice throughout the building whenever their children are in our care. If you would like to volunteer or participate in the activities or operations of the school, please feel free to discuss your interest with the director.

Visitors (other than parents) are allowed in child care areas only at the discretion of the program director and will be accompanied by a staff member at all times.

In cases where Family Court or other legal entities have established visitation or custody rights, a copy of the orders must be provided to TAAP. The court orders will be strictly followed unless the custodial parent requests a more liberal variation of the court order in writing.

Arrival and Departure: You (as parent/legal guardian) or an authorized adult must accompany your child into the school and place him/her under staff supervision before leaving the premises. For the protection of all the children, TAAP maintains a strict release policy. Our enrollment form provides space to list names of individuals (other than parents) to whom the child may be released. We also require advance notice in writing or by phone call if someone other than yourself will be picking up your child. TAAP will not release any child to someone other than the parent/legal guardian without advance notice. A picture identification may be required at the time of pick up. If your child has recently been enrolled at our center and the caregiver on duty does not feel confident that she knows you, she may ask you as the parent for identification as well. Please do not be offended by this. When it comes to the safety of your child, it is better to be completely safe rather than completely sorry!

It is also your responsibility to be timely in your arrival and departure each day. There is a \$1 per MINUTE per family charge for care after closing time. This money should be paid directly to the staff member who is caring for your child. Please notify us if an emergency prevents your timely arrival.

At the end of each day, please check your child's cubby for notices, artwork, or special projects.

Scheduling Changes: To maintain our quality program and to satisfy licensing regulations, we schedule adequate staff to care for the number of children enrolled. TAAP is not responsible to reduce or refund tuition for daily absences due to weather, holidays, illness, or vacation. Our policy does not *require* us to provide "make-up" days. We appreciate it if you call to inform us that your child cannot attend on any given day due to unexpected illnesses or events.

If your child will be away on an extended leave, or if you are planning to withdraw them from enrollment at TAAP, please inform the director in writing at least two weeks in advance.

You may wish to request other schedule changes as well, and we will do our best to accommodate them. Again, please make your request in writing. We cannot guarantee to hold your place for extended periods (especially if you have not communicated your plans to us) or to allow changes if our attendance patterns and staffing cannot accommodate them.

Parental Financial Obligations: Our year at TAAP is divided into four sessions (fall, winter, spring, and summer) with twelve weeks in each session. There are three equal payments in each session, with a total of twelve per year. These payments are due during the first week of each month/section. Please see the payment schedule included with your enrollment packet for details on various attendance options and additional fees such as registration, curriculum fees, and the summer activity fee.

Once you have chosen a schedule for your child's attendance, you are responsible to pay his/her charges each month/section regardless of the number of days he/she actually attends. We schedule our staff based on the number of children registered to attend each day. We expect them to be faithful in their commitment to arrive on time each day and take good care of your child. And we expect you, as parents, to be faithful in fulfilling your financial obligations so that we can fairly pay them for that faithful service to your child. Please remember that payment is due regardless of days missed due to illness, holidays, or other school closing.

Holidays: TAAP is closed for the following holidays: Good Friday and the Monday following Easter Sunday, Memorial Day, Independence Day, Labor Day, Thanksgiving Day and the Friday after Thanksgiving, Christmas and New Year's Days and the week between them.

Please Note That: TAAP receives the right to withdraw a child who has developmental, behavioral, health, or discipline problems which cause him/her to harm other children or disrupt the program. At any time during a child's enrollment, TAAP has the right to withdraw a family for the best interest of the school. Habitual absenteeism or failure to pay fees will also result in termination of enrollment.

Section 5: Health and Safety

Sick Child Policy: It is TAAP's policy to temporarily exclude children from care who may be infectious or who demonstrate physical symptoms that require continual one-on-one care. Deciding when a child is infectious is sometimes a matter of opinion; however, the guidelines we have established are in compliance with licensing regulations. We will use these guidelines even if they differ from the opinion of your pediatrician. Although we are sensitive to the fact that as a working parent you have responsibilities at work, we must make safeguarding the health of all the children at the school our first priority. The environment we provide is intimate, and in spite of all the health procedures we employ, the most effective means of minimizing the spread of infection is to exclude children who may be infectious.

The director has the final decision on the exclusion of children.

Guidelines for Excluding Children: If your child has any of the following conditions he/she should remain home from school until he/she is free of symptoms without the influence of medication for at least 24 hours or until you have a doctor's note that says he/she may return:

*A fever over 100 degrees or Vomiting and/or Diarrhea
Eye discharge or red, itchy, watery eyes, unidentified rashes,
excessive coughing, sore throat, excessive nasal discharge
Other: severe pain or discomfort, jaundice, difficulty
breathing, swollen joints or lymph nodes,
blood/pus from ears or skin, urine, or stool,
symptoms of impetigo, lice, scabies, or strep throat.*

Please refer to the contagious disease chart posted on the board near the office for additional information.

Please Note: These same guidelines apply to the exclusion of staff members due to illness.

Communicable Diseases: We will adhere to Michigan Child Care licensing standards on communicable disease and exclusion times. In cases of certain communicable disease, TAAP is required to file a report with the Department of Health within 24 hours so that control measures can be used. We ask the parents/guardians and staff members to notify TAAP within 24 hours if a child or family member has developed a known or suspected communicable disease. If a child has not been fully vaccinated for some of these diseases, he/she may be excluded from school during an outbreak of a "vaccine-preventable" illness as directed by the State Health Department. All parents will be informed in writing if a communicable disease is reported. Examples of reportable diseases include, but are not limited to: *Measles, German Measles, Lyme Disease, Whooping Cough, Tuberculosis, Salmonella, Rubella, Giardiasis, Spinal Meningitis, Mumps, Hepatitis A, and Shigella* (The communicable disease chart is located on the bulletin board near the office.) If your child contracts a communicable illness, please notify TAAP immediately. We must post (both on the bulletin board and by email) any incidents of contagious illness to alert other parents. Upon the return of a child absent due to a contagious illness, a signed statement from a licensed physician stating that they are no longer contagious must be presented.

Please Note: These same guidelines apply to the exclusion and return of staff members and volunteers due to illness.

Accident, Incident, or Injury: While in the care of TAAP, no child will be left without adult supervision, regardless of whether the children are sleeping, playing, eating, or otherwise engaged. This is the most important rule of all playground and classroom supervision. Supervision specifically encompasses, but is not limited to, the following times and areas: arrival, departure, school activities, free choice activities, rest time, eating time, bathroom visits, walking in the hallways, playing on the playground, or any time the child is in the care of our staff and their parent/guardian is not present.

In spite of the care and vigilance our staff exercises during the day, it is possible for accidents, incidents, or injuries to occur. In the case of a minor injury or an incident, we will provide first aid if needed and call the parent to inform him/her of the situation.

In the case of serious injuries, our first call will be to 911 and our second call to the parents. First aid will be administered and someone will remain with the child until a parent/guardian arrives.

Emergency Procedures: Our caregivers are required to maintain current certificates in First Aid and CPR. There is always a caregiver in the building with this training. All staff members are trained in blood borne pathogens procedures before they are allowed unsupervised contact with children.

In addition to this, emergency drills will be conducted on a regular basis, and staff are trained in these procedures at the time of employment and twice a year thereafter. Detailed emergency plans are posted in each classroom. You will notice that the alternate safe location is not specified, for safety reasons. When your child is enrolled, you will be provided with the address and phone number of this location, as well as the entry code for the front door.

Notifying Parents: While your child is in our care, we will notify you any time we notice changes in their health or behavior that concern us. In the case of accident, illness, injury, or any other emergencies, notifying you will be one of our very first priorities. Your contact information is always accessible in every classroom and in the office. Please make sure you keep it current! We will try to reach you by phone or by text, and will contact other names you have provided if you cannot be reached.

Section 6: Other Information

Transportation and Field Trips: Troy Adventist Academy Preschool does not provide transportation to and from the school. Should there ever be an occasion when a teacher/caregiver transports a child in his/her vehicle without the parent present, a permission slip signed by parents/guardian will be required. A copy of this slip will be kept in the child's file at the center.

Calendars and Schedules: You will notice that your enrollment packet includes a sample schedule. You will find more specific schedules posted outside each classroom as well, along with the lesson plan/activity schedule for each week. Monthly calendars with upcoming events and lunch and snack menus will be available on the parent table near the office. Each September, a calendar of events for the year will be available, which will include holidays/vacations, and early Friday closings along with other pertinent information.

In general, TAAP will be closed on the following holidays: New Year's Day, Good Friday and the Monday following Easter Sunday, Memorial Day, Independence Day (July 4), Labor Day, Thanksgiving Day and the Friday that follows it, and one week during the Christmas holidays. In addition, TAAP is closed for two staff training/preparation days - one in the spring and one in the fall. Please remember that regular payments are due even during months that include holidays.

We use an online system called HiMama to keep track of attendance and send daily reports. We also communicate with you via text or email using this system. Please be sure that you have provided accurate email addresses and cell phone numbers to make this possible.

Bad Weather Conditions: TAAP will do its best to remain open regardless of weather conditions. In the event of weather conditions severe enough to require closing the preschool, you will be notified by text or email by 6:30am.

Agreement: Troy Adventist Academy Preschool has outlined its duties and responsibilities, as well as your obligations as parents of an enrolled child. These policies have been carefully explained in order to ensure the comfort and protection of your child. We will do our best to provide your child with a program to suit his/her needs, and an environment in which he/she can feel both secure and free to grow.

As a parent of a child who is enrolled at TAAP, I agree to abide by and adhere to all policies set forth in this handbook.

Parent's Signature and Date

(This signature page is for your records. There is a similar statement for our records included with the enrollment application and agreement.)